Airmail to the Moon

By Tom Birdseye

ORA MAE: *(with a deep southern accent)* My name is Ora Mae Cotton of Crabapple Orchard, and last night somebody stole my tooth. I'd been down at the creek catching crawdads when it started tingling – kind of like if you missed your toast and peanut butter and bit your teeth really hard instead. That was three weeks ago. I was popcorn-in-the-pan excited, for sure that tooth was gonna fall out any second. But Dadaw (that's what I call my daddy) always says not to milk the cow when she's asleep (which is Crabapple Orchard talk for not blabbing to everybody about something before you're sure of what you're blabbing about). So I didn't tell a soul.

INTRODUCTION

Losing a tooth is an exciting and memorable part of childhood. It brings thoughts of the magical Tooth Fairy who exchanges money for teeth.

The Tooth Fairy made her first known appearance on September 27, 1908 in an article by the Chicago Daily Tribune . . . and parents under the guise of fairies have been forking out money ever since! Thanks, Chicago!!

Hold on to your wallets, parents: As of 2021, Tooth Fairy payouts have hit an all-time high. According to Delta Dental, the average cash payout for a tooth today is nearly 5 dollars! My biggest haul was a quarter!

In this tale, Ora Mae Cotton's faith in the tooth fairy is shaken and she is bound and determined to investigate her stolen 1st tooth.

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ORA MAE: Then last Monday, while fetching the mail at the county road, I stuck my tongue out at my pesky neighbor, Merrietta Bean, and gave her a big raspberry like this – PPLLUBB! The vibration from my tongue flapping against my teeth popped that chomper of mine as loose as a goose on ice skates. So I told the world about my first tooth coming out . . . whether they wanted to hear or not.

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By Thursday that tooth was so wobbly it was just hanging on by one root and a flap of skin. I could push it all the way out between my lips with my tongue ***and*** help Mama slop the hogs at the same time.

Then Friday, right after my big brother Bo Dean and my little sister Kelsey Ann got into a fight at the dinner table over whether Arlene Peterson's pigs really kneel and pray before they eat, that loose tooth of mine fell right out of my mouth – plop – and landed smack in the middle of my spaghetti.

MAMA: Be sure and put that tooth under [your] pillow. That way the tooth fairy [will] come get it and give [you] some money.

ORA MAE: Money! Shout howdy. Mama didn't say how much. But I figured it had to be at least a thousand dollars, or maybe even a hundred dollars. I was so excited that I hurried to bed as quick as a dropped cat just so I could dream about all the things I was going to buy. But like I said, somebody stole my tooth. So I guess I dreamed all night for nothing. First thing this morning when I discovered the crime. I ran lickety-split to find Mama. She was in the root cellar, up to her elbows in rutabagas. *(To Mama, yelling)* Mama! Is the tooth fairy a crook like ol' Hester Jenkins that stole the parking meter from in front of the county courthouse?

MAMA: Why no, Oreo. The tooth fairy is as honest as flowers in the spring.

ORA MAE: That's what I thought. *(fuming)* Well, then somebody besides the tooth fairy stole my tooth. Somebody so crooked they screw their socks on every morning. And when I catch 'em, I'm gonna open up a can of gotcha and send 'em airmail to the moon!

MAMA: Oreo, I don't think anybody would steal your tooth. Maybe the tooth fairy is putting it on a string with other teeth to make a beautiful necklace. That's what I've heard she does. She probably forgot to leave you some money and will remember tonight.

ORA MAE: *(To audience)* That didn't seem likely to me. What good is a tooth fairy that forgets?

MAMA: Why don't you go ask your daddy. Maybe he knows something we don't.

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ORA MAE: *(To audience)* Aha! He's a real thinker, my Dadaw is. Why, he even sells watermelons to the grocery store. He knows mighty near everything.

DADAW: *(Singing and shaving with a straight razor)*

ORA MAE: I heard Dadaw before I spied him. He was out by the tire swing shaving and singing at the same time (which is mighty dangerous if you ask me). Half his face was shaving cream. The other half was "as smooth as a baby's belly," as he liked to say. *(To Dadaw)* Dadaw! Some crook stole my tooth. And when I catch 'em, I'm gonna open up a can of gotcha and send 'em airmail to the moon!"

DADAW: Oreo, I don't think anybody would steal your tooth. Maybe the tooth fairy has it and is grinding it up in a big machine. That tooth dust might come out as money. Then the tooth fairy could us it to buy you some real estate. Like one of them condominiums at Miami Beach.

ORA MAE: *(To audience)* What would I do with a condominium at Miami Beach? *(To Dadaw, shouting)* Tooth dust? But Dadaw! Somebody stole my tooth!

DADAW: *(rubbing his chin and nodding)* Why don't you go ask your brother. He usually knows more than he tells.

ORA MAE: Aha! My brother Bo Dean is as ornery as a bull in a beehive. And he lost two teeth last week when he fell out of the hayloft. I'll bet he stole my tooth and glued it straight into his mouth. I'm gonna get that boy! And when I do, I'm gonna open up a can of gotcha and send him airmail to the moon!

BO DEAN: *(calmly, as he sneaks up on a frog or snake to catch)* I didn't steal your tooth, Oreo. What would I want with girl teeth, anyway? They don't fit boys.

ORA MAE: *(to audience)* I hadn't thought of that.

BO DEAN: Are you sure you didn't just give it to the tooth fairy, no money down?

ORA MAE: *(yelling)* Why would I do such a thing?! That's stupid!

BO DEAN: *(Shhhs Ora Mae)* The tooth fairy saves teeth to give to babies, right, Oreo?

ORA MAE: *(whispering)* Not according to Mama or Dadaw, she don't.

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BO DEAN: *(Still pre-occupied with his hunt)* Well, according to me, Bo Dean Cotton, she does. That's so they can chew on rocks and shoes and stuff. *(whispering as he makes a grab for the reptile)* Where do you think Kelsey Ann got her teeth when she was little?

ORA MAE: *(to audience)* Aha! Maybe Bo Dean has a point. Kelsey Ann is as ornery as Bo Dean plus ten. She ***had*** to be the one that stole my tooth! I'll get that little diddle-do! And when I do, I'm gonna open up a can of gotcha and send her airmail to the moon! (she races off to find Kelsey Ann) Kelsey Ann Cotton! Give me my tooth. I know you stole it!

KELSEY ANN: *(in the middle of a tea party)* Pig feathers. I'm as sweet as roses in the snow. The tooth fairy steals teeth, not me. She makes them into doorknobs. Didn't you know that Oreo?

ORA MAE: Not according to Mama, Dadaw, or Bo Dean she doesn't. You took it!

KELSEY ANN: She does too, 'cause I didn't.

ORA MAE: Does not, you did!

KELSEY ANN: Does too, I didn't.

ORA MAE: Does not, you did!

KELSEY ANN: *(giggling)* I'll bet you threw it away, Oreo. It's probably in the bottom of the garbage can stuck in the middle of a blob of leftover spaghetti. That's how forgetful you are. That tooth will never be a doorknob.

ORA MAE: *(to audience)* That did it! I was so mad I was ready to scream. ***Nobody*** really knew what the tooth fairy was up to. And ***nobody*** was the lop-eared rascal that stole my tooth. I was just about to pop my cork clean out of Crabapple Orchard. But instead, I just stood there looking at my sister, and . . . (Ora Mae starts crying – loud and wailing) Somebody stole my tooth . . . and when I catch 'em I'm gonna open up a can of gotcha and send 'em airmail to the moon. *(She sticks her hands down deep in her pockets and a shocked expression comes over her face. She stops crying)*

My name is Ora Mae Cotton of Crabapple Orchard. And right now I feel like a possum up a plum tree. I'm as embarrassed as a zebra without stripes. *(sheepishly and she hold out her hand)* You see, there's this little hard thing in the bottom of my pants pocket. It's right

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where I left it. *(beat)* I wonder if the tooth fairy ever sends motor-mouth kids like me airmail to the moon?

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